395 SQUADRON ALUMNI ASSOCIATION

Alumni Notes

395 Squadron Alumni Association Newsletter

September 2024

Overview

The Alumni as well as other organizations have their challenges re-engaging members and the organization's activities since COVID has finished. Apparently there is another strain of COVID surfacing across Canada.

As we conclude the 100th Anniversary of the RCAF and move to another notch on the fence post, the Alumni would like to organize some activities. Maybe a pub night, crud tournament or just socialize at your neighbourhood Legion. We are always open to ideas, so if you have any activities you would like to see the Alumni involved in please send an email.

Our affilated unit, 417 Combat Support Squadron, has had several moves since pre-COVID. They moved from their hangar (Hgr 2) to AETE's facility. 417's old hangar is now gone. With the incoming F-35 coming to Cold Lake many activities are occurring. Now 417 has moved to the old 419 Hangar at the south end of the base. In this feature, we are focusing on the history of 417 Squadron.

The Alumni sent a couple of email notices out regarding the passing of two of our former Commanding Officers, Major Don Ste Croix and Major Graham Pilkington. Both officers had a significant impact on the unit and kept the character and personality of the squadron from one command to the other. They will not only be missed as officers but as supporters of the cadet movement.

Welcome
to the new
Commanding Officer of 395
Squadron RCAC Edmonton

Captain Deborah Smart



Highlights in this edition:

- Overview - p1
- 417 Squadron History - p2
- Remembering Ste Croix & Pilkington - p3
- Reunion Update - p4
- COC 395 Squadron, Jun 2024 - p4
- Our Squadron - Update - p4

A Brief History of 417 Combat Support Squadron, Our Affiliated Unit

417 Combat Support Squadron is an Air Force unit with the Canadian Forces. Based at CFB Cold Lake it provides helicopter support to the base operations. Since 1994, it has also provided Search and Rescue.

History

417 Squadron was a Royal Canadian Air Force squadron formed in England on 27 November 1941 at RAF Charmy Down and was known as the “City of Windsor” squadron. It was equipped with the Hurricane and later the Spitfire. It was initially deployed



in Egypt and followed the allied advance through the western desert. With the defeat of axis forces in North Africa, the squadron followed the advance through Italy. It disbanded in Italy on July 1, 1945.

The squadron reactivated in Canada on June 1, 1947 at Rivers, Manitoba. It was equipped with the Mustang for army close support training until August 1, 1948.



Reformed as a part of the Canadian Forces in 1970 it operated as an operational training squadron on the CF-104 Starfighter at CFB Cold Lake. The squadron disbanded in 1983 with the retirement of the CF-104 fleet.

On April 1, 1993 417 Combat Support squadron was formed from CFB Cold Lake Base Flight plus aircraft servicing and maintenance elements of the Wing Maintenance organization. The squadron continued Base Flight’s operations with ten CT-133 Silver Stars and three CH-118 Iroquois. When Base Rescue Moose



Jaw was disbanded in 1993, 417 Squadron gained two of their CH-118s, to operate a total of five.

In July 1995 417 Squadron received three CH-146 Griffon helicopters and the five CH-118s were retired. The CT-133 was retired in 2001.



Significance The squadron operated with the ‘Eighth Army’ in North Africa, in the Sicilian landings, and in Italy in close support of the army. The palm tree suggests the desert; the sword, air support to the army; and the fasces, the fighting in Italy.

Motto

Supporting Liberty and Justice
That Others May Live

Battle Honours

- Defence of Britain 1942
- Egypt and Libya 1942-43
- North Africa 1943
- Sicily 1943
- Italy 1943-45
- Salerno
- Ansio and Nettuno
- Gustaff Line
- Gothic Line



Veterans Association Food Bank "Veterans Helping Veterans"

The VAFB "recognizes any person who is currently serving or has honourably served in the Canadian Armed Forces. The VAFB also recognizes and offers support to those currently serving, honourably discharged or honourably released Commonwealth Allies, members of the Royal Canadian Mounted Police, Peacekeepers, Merchant Marines, or Ferry Command (Coast Guard). Support will be extended to spouses, widows, widowers, and any dependent children in need. Proof of military service or affiliation required."

As with most food banks, food isn't the only assistance that is available. In addition to providing food hampers and gift cards, VAFB also offers services such as: intake support, peer support, VAC claims and medical referrals, emergency veteran assistance, workshops and training programs in partnership with other organizations, just to name a few.

The Veterans Association Food Bank Edmonton is located at 15783 - 116 Ave. Requests for food, finding support and connecting to community resources in Edmonton can be made by calling 403-FOR-VETS (403-367-8387). Staff is on call to assist 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. Please call 911 if you require emergency assistance.

Introduction - SWO 417 Squadron



Over the years, 395 Squadron Alumni communicates with the SWO of 417 Squadron. The Alumni looks forward to working with **MWO Chris Downey**

Welcome!

Major Don Ste Croix CD

30 Sep 1950 - 24 Jan 2024



Donald was born to be a leader and a mentor. From an early age he was involved with the Canadian military, later in life a commercial pilot and instructor. In his personal life he became a part of the Amateur Karate Foundation and enjoyed teaching students young and old. His tough love approach saw many students and cadets flourish into successful careers. He found joy and brotherhood with the good folks at the VPMC, and always enjoyed a cold beer after a long ride.

Major Graham Daniel Pilkington CD

1977 - 9 Mar 2024



Graham started with the air cadet program when he was 12 years old. This began his biggest hobby to date and forged many friendships over the years. He learned so much from those in the program and had many adventures or shenanigans as he would call them with his closest friends. As a result of being in the program he would go on to join the Cadet Instructor Cadre and spent over 20 years helping shape the many youth and adult staff that went through the program under his leadership.

He will be dearly missed by all those who knew him through the Canadian Cadet Organization and 700 Wing Association.

Some of the patches of 417 Squadron over the years.

Alumni Association Reunion Update



Formed 11 Apr 1946 - Received Charter 3 July 1946

We are up to our 79th year anniversary of our 395 Squadron Charter. At this point we have not planned anything for this anniversary but we will definitely be looking for our 80th in 2026.

The Alumni executive will be looking for volunteers to help plan and organize the event once we are given the green light to go ahead. A year from now, we will start planning. Join the team. Approximately 10 months of planning goes into putting on this type of an event. Stay tuned. Contact us by using this email link.

Our Cadet Squadron

The reopening units and cadet activities have been slow. No more on-line parades. All units are now having live parades and are coming to life. Activities including weekly parades, camping, familiarization flying and gliding are slowly moving forward. Summer camps have returned but are not yet at the pre-pandemic numbers. The gliding and flying scholarships are also not at the pre-COVID.

Familiarization flying in a glider is still trying to launch. This is due to a shortage of trained glider pilots because no training took place during to the previous summers. This has created a chain reaction, affecting the caudre of pilots. It may take up to two years to bring everything back to pre-pandemic levels once the flying is approved by DND.

In the past, the Alberta Provincial Committee scholarship boards were where cadets would all convene from around the province to be interviewed for the many scholarship opportunities available. The bulk of the scholarships are now processed by the military. There have been many comments made that this new system is affective in identifying the best candidate for the scholarship.

395 Squadron Change of Command - June 2024



L to R: Maj Brittney Pilkington (Outgoing CO), Maj Eddie Brown (Presiding Officer, CO 417 Sqn), Captain Deborah Smart (Incoming CO)

395 Squadron Alumni Steering Committee Executive 2024-2025

Brian Andrus
Chair/Treasurer

Karen Butkowski
Co-Chair/Admin Coordinator

Nick Nimchuck
Archives

Erwin Loewen
Archives

Raphael Mlynarski
Webmaster

Joe Luce
Event Coordinator

Nanette Booth
Graphic Design

Sylvia Loewen
Member at Large

Stacy Urwin
Member at Large

395 Alumni
c/o 7404 – 180 Street
Edmonton, AB T5T 2K8

395 Alumni Website
LINK

Email
Email Link